

Abstract

Facilitators and Barriers to Students Gaining Experience in Community Sporting Clubs

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Community sporting clubs can provide university students with opportunities to apply academic learning, develop practical and transferable skills, and establish industry connections. However, the conditions that enable or constrain students' participation in work-integrated learning (WIL) and volunteering within these settings are not well understood. This study explored the facilitators and barriers experienced by university students gaining experience through WIL and volunteering in community sporting clubs. Individual semi-structured online interviews were conducted with 14 participants: four current university students undertaking WIL placements and 10 community sport-club volunteers or mentors. Interviews were transcribed verbatim and analysed using reflexive thematic analysis, informed by Self-Determination Theory. Four themes and nine sub-themes were identified: Environment (guidance and mentorship, culture, and family and social influence); Motivations (personal and career motivations); Role (education, employability, and application of skills); and Opportunity (access to industry connections and flexibility). Active mentorship, inclusive club cultures, personal interest in sport, meaningful responsibility, access to networks, and flexible placement arrangements supported students' engagement and learning. In contrast, unclear expectations, limited capacity, rigid

organisational or university processes, unpaid work, financial pressure, competing commitments, unequal network access, and negative social influences limited the accessibility and value of these experiences. The findings show that meaningful and equitable WIL opportunities require connection between universities and community sporting clubs. Clear learning goals, named mentors, regular feedback, structured university–club partnerships, and flexible arrangements may improve student participation, skill development, and career readiness in the sport industry.